

FIELD RESOURCE

Garden and Outdoor: Four Weekends to a Sale- Ready Yard

A weekend-by-weekend checklist for Brisbane vendors

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Buyers walking into a Brisbane home spend more time in the yard than most vendors expect. The back deck, the lawn, the side path, the front kerb. These spaces are where buyers picture their weekends, their kids, their dog. Four weekends is enough time to take a tired yard from neglected to genuinely appealing, without spending money on landscapers you do not need. This guide assumes you are starting roughly four weeks out from photography or the first open home, and it works around the heat, humidity, and storm patterns of subtropical Brisbane.

Weekend one: Clear and assess

The first weekend is about removing everything that is dead, broken, or in the wrong place, then standing back and seeing the yard the way a buyer will see it. Do not plant or buy anything yet. Brisbane gardens almost always reveal good bones once the clutter is gone.

- ☐ Walk the boundary of the property and pull out anything dead, broken, or rusting. Old pots, snapped stakes, faded plastic toys, dead palms in pots, the lot.
- ☐ Cut back any plant pushing into a path, fence, or window. Overgrown agapanthus, mother-in-law tongue clumps, runaway umbrella trees, and overgrown frangipani are the usual culprits.
- ☐ Empty and rinse the gutters if you can do so safely. Brisbane storms drop a lot of leaf litter, and clogged gutters show up in drone photos and during heavy rain at an open home.
- ☐ Take photos of the yard from the same angles a real estate photographer would use: front kerb, back deck, looking back at the house from the rear fence, side passages.
- ☐ List every job you can see in those photos. Bare patches in the lawn, mouldy fence panels, mulch that has thinned out, weeds in the driveway cracks, peeling paint on the back step. This list runs the next three weekends.
- ☐ Hire a green waste skip or book a council kerbside collection if you have more than two ute loads of cuttings. Stockpiles of green waste behind a shed get worse, not better, in Brisbane humidity.

Weekend two: Lawn, mulch, and edges

The single biggest visual lift in a Brisbane yard is a healthy lawn with sharp edges and freshly mulched garden beds. This is the weekend to do the unglamorous work that photographs better than almost anything else.

- ☐ Mow the lawn slightly higher than usual, about 35 to 50mm for Sir Walter or common couch. Lawn cut too short in Brisbane summer browns off within days.
- ☐ Edge every garden bed, path, and driveway with a line trimmer or half-moon edger. A clean edge does more visual work than any new plant.
- ☐ Patch bare lawn patches with turf rolls cut to fit. Buying a few rolls of Sir Walter or a shade-tolerant buffalo and laying them now gives them three weeks to knit in. Seed does not establish reliably in this timeframe.
- ☐ Top up mulch in every garden bed to roughly 75mm depth. Sugar cane mulch or forest fines look natural and break down well. Avoid bright red dyed bark, which reads as cheap on camera.
- ☐ Pull weeds from driveway cracks, paver joints, and along fence lines. A weed killer applied this weekend has time to brown off and be swept away before photos.
- ☐ Wash the front path and the back deck with a stiff broom and a bucket of sugar soap, or hire a pressure washer for half a day. Mossy concrete and slimy timber are the two things buyers notice first.

Weekend three: Plant, prune, and refresh

Now that the yard is clean and the lawn is doing its job, this is the weekend to add the small amount of new planting that will actually make a difference. Resist buying twenty plants. Five to ten well-placed pots and a few in-ground feature plants do more than a full landscape redo.

- ☐ Buy plants that suit the actual light conditions of each spot. Full sun spots take frangipani, plumbago, gardenia, and most natives. Dappled or shaded spots take cordyline, bromeliads, philodendron, peace lily, and clivia.
- ☐ Do not plant in full sun on a 32-degree Brisbane day. Plant late afternoon, water in well, and water again the next morning.
- ☐ Use large, simple pots in matte black, charcoal, or natural concrete by the front door and on the back deck. One large pot looks more considered than three small ones.
- ☐ Prune frangipani, hibiscus, and any leggy shrubs back to a clean shape. Brisbane shrubs respond fast to a hard prune in spring and early summer.
- ☐ Fertilise the lawn lightly with a slow-release product. Avoid heavy nitrogen feeds the week before photos, which can scorch in heat.
- ☐ Replace any tired pot plants on the deck or front porch. A herb pot near the back door, a flowering gardenia by the front step, and a structural cordyline in a corner are all reliable Brisbane choices.

Weekend four: Detail and stage

The final weekend is about presentation. Most of the heavy work is done. This is the weekend to get the outdoor area looking like the lifestyle photos in the listing.

- ☐ Oil or clean the timber deck. A water-based decking oil applied on a cool morning dries within the day. Avoid oil-based products that take longer to cure in humidity.
- ☐ Wash outdoor furniture, plump cushions, and replace any cushion covers that are sun-faded. Faded cushions read as dated even when the furniture is fine.
- ☐ Set the outdoor table for two or four. A simple linen runner, a few plates, two glasses, and a small vase of cuttings from the garden. No food.
- ☐ Coil and hide hoses. Move bins to the side of the house or garage. Tuck away kids toys, dog bowls, and pet beds.
- ☐ Replace any blown garden lights or path lights. Working low-voltage lighting along a path or up a feature tree gives the yard a second life in twilight photos.
- ☐ Walk the kerb. Sweep the footpath and gutter in front of the house. Wipe the letterbox, the front number, and the front door handle. Buyers form a view of the home before they have stepped inside.

Tools and materials checklist

You do not need a shed full of equipment. This is the short list that covers most Brisbane yards in a four-week prep. Borrow or hire what you do not own. A pressure washer for half a day from a Bunnings hire desk costs less than buying one.

- ☐ Line trimmer or half-moon edger for clean garden bed and path edges.
- ☐ Stiff outdoor broom and a bucket of sugar soap for paths and decks.
- ☐ Pressure washer (hired) for concrete, pavers, and rendered walls.
- ☐ Sharp secateurs and loppers for pruning frangipani, hibiscus, and shrubs.
- ☐ Sugar cane mulch or forest fines for garden beds. Calculate one bale per square metre at 75mm depth.
- ☐ Slow-release lawn fertiliser and a basic spreader.
- ☐ Decking oil suited to your deck timber, applied on a dry, cool morning.
- ☐ Heavy-duty contractor bags or a hired green waste skip for cuttings.
- ☐ Garden gloves, sun hat, and water. Brisbane heat between November and March is not optional weather.

Plant ideas for subtropical Brisbane

These plants are reliable in Brisbane gardens and look good in photos without months of growing-in time. Match the plant to the light. The most common mistake is buying a sun-loving plant for a shaded courtyard, or a fern for a hot west-facing strip.

- ☐ Full sun: frangipani, plumbago, bougainvillea on a fence or arch, hibiscus, gardenia in a sunny pot, lomandra Tanika as a strappy ground cover, dwarf agapanthus.
- ☐ Filtered or dappled sun: cordyline in red or burgundy, bromeliads, clivia, peace lily in a pot, gardenia florida in a courtyard, dwarf cardamom for soft green texture.
- ☐ Deep shade: bromeliads, philodendron Xanadu, peace lily, native violet as a ground cover, monstera against a fence, ZZ plant in pots near a back door.
- ☐ Lawn for sun: Sir Walter buffalo or common couch. Both handle Brisbane summer when watered well in the first three weeks.
- ☐ Lawn for partial shade: Sir Walter buffalo. Couch fails in shade and is the most common reason a back lawn looks patchy.
- ☐ Pot plants near the front door: a single large frangipani in a matte pot, a clipped buxus ball, or a structural cordyline. Pick one and stop.
- ☐ Avoid: anything too tropical-looking that needs constant water, large bird of paradise in small spaces, agave or cactus near paths where children visit, and any plant flowering only in winter when your campaign is in summer.

Maintenance during the campaign

The campaign typically runs three to four weeks from photography through to auction or contract. The yard needs to look the same on the last open home as it did in the photos. This is the rhythm that holds it together.

- ☐ Mow once a week, the day before the open home. Edge every second mow.
- ☐ Water the lawn deeply twice a week in summer, ideally in the early morning. Light daily watering produces shallow roots and a yellow lawn.
- ☐ Sweep the deck, paths, and front kerb the morning of every open home. Brisbane wind drops leaves overnight.
- ☐ Top up mulch if a storm has scattered it. Keep half a bag spare in the shed.
- ☐ Replace any tired pot plant the day before each open home rather than nursing it along.
- ☐ Watch the forecast. A summer storm two hours before an open home can flatten plants and pool water on the deck. Have a towel ready and a backup plan to mop the deck before buyers arrive.
- ☐ Keep bins out of sight on every open home day, even if they were emptied the night before.

A sale-ready yard in Brisbane is not about a complete landscape overhaul. It is about a clean lawn, sharp edges, fresh mulch, the right plants for the light, and the discipline to keep it that way for the four weeks of the campaign. Four weekends of honest work outperforms a rushed weekend of panic spending every time.

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